

QI WHIZ!

Diagnosis Pocket Companion



*Vital Substances · Eight Principles
Pulse & Tongue Diagnosis*

*A Pocket Guide to Not Panicking About
Pulses, Patterns & Points on the Tongue*

VOLUME 1



A NOTE BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Somewhere in the next few years, you are going to have a patient sit down, tell you what's wrong, and go quiet waiting for you to say something useful. This book won't be in the room with you. But the hours behind it will be. The slides you read twice. The pulse you took on your roommate at 11pm because a quality finally clicked.

I made this because I wanted to actually remember this stuff, not just pass a quiz on it. Somewhere along the way it turned into something worth handing to the people learning it alongside me.

This medicine has stuck around for two thousand years because people kept writing it down, arguing about it, and passing it forward. Every single one of them started exactly where you are right now: holding a wrist for the first time, honestly not sure if what you're feeling counts as anything. That's not you falling behind. That's just the first step, and everyone who ever got good at this took it too.

Wherever you are in the program when you're reading this, keep going. The patterns start talking to each other before you even notice it happening. And somewhere in the middle of all this memorizing, it quietly stops being memorization and starts being how you see people.

For the acupuncturist you are about to become.

How This Book Works

Every entry has two parts.

Top — what Schrier taught. Straight from the lecture. This is what gets examined.

BOTTOM — PLAIN LANGUAGE

Drawn from outside references to make the thing easier to actually feel or picture. Use it to build intuition; use the top half to answer questions. Sources named per entry.

Part One — Vital Substance Patterns. Qi, Blood, Fluid & Jing patterns: Deficiency, Stagnation, Stasis, Excess. The foundation everything after it builds on.

Part Two — Eight Principles. Bā Gāng: the four-axis frame every pattern in this book sits inside.

Part Three — Pulse Diagnosis. The eight components of a normal pulse, then all 28 qualities, one per page.

Part Four — Tongue Diagnosis. Color, shape, and coating, body and sublingual veins — one finding per page.

Read front to back once. After that, this is a lookup book.

Table of Contents

PART ONE

Vital Substance Patterns

1. Qi Deficiency	10
2. Sinking Qi	11
3. Qi Stagnation	12
4. Rebellious Qi	13
5. Blood Deficiency	14
6. Blood Stasis — Overview	15
7. Qi Stagnation vs. Blood Stasis	16
8. Blood Stasis — Liver & Heart	17
9. Blood Stasis — Lung, Stomach, Intestines & Uterus	18
10. Heat in the Blood	19
11. Loss of Blood	20
12. Deficiency of Body Fluids	21
13. Edema	22
14. Phlegm — Substantial vs. Non-Substantial	23
15. Types of Substantial Phlegm	24
16. Types of Non-Substantial Phlegm	25
17. Essence (Jing) Deficiency	26

PART TWO

Eight Principles

1. Exterior	28
2. Interior	29
3. Exterior Cold	30
4. Exterior Heat	31
5. Full Exterior	32
6. Empty Exterior	33
7. Full Cold	34
8. Empty Cold	35
9. Full Heat	36
10. Empty Heat	37
11. Full / Excess	38
12. Empty / Deficiency	39
13. Yin Pattern	40
14. Yang Pattern	41
15. False Heat, True Cold	42
16. False Cold, True Heat	43
17. Cold Exterior, Heat Interior	44
18. Heat Exterior, Cold Interior	45
19. Heat Above, Cold Below	46
20. Combined Heat and Cold	47

PART THREE

Pulse Diagnosis

Components of a Normal Pulse

1. Width	49
2. Depth	50
3. Rate	51
4. Rhythm	52
5. Length	53
6. Tension	54
7. Shape	55
8. Strength	56

The 28 Qualities

1. Floating	60
2. Deep / Submerged	62
3. Slow	63
4. Rapid	64
5. Empty / Deficient	65
6. Full / Excessive	66
7. Slippery	67
8. Choppy	68
9. Long	69
10. Short	70
11. Overflowing / Flooding	71

12. Fine / Thin	72
13. Minute / Faint	73
14. Tight	74
15. Wiry	75
16. Slowed-Down / Moderate	76
17. Hollow	77
18. Leather	78
19. Firm / Confined	79
20. Soggy	80
21. Weak / Frail	81
22. Scattered	82
23. Hidden	83
24. Moving	84
25. Hasty	85
26. Knotted	86
27. Intermittent	87
28. Hurried / Racing	88

PART FOUR

Tongue Diagnosis

1. How to Inspect the Tongue	92
2. Medications & the Tongue	93
3. Tongue-Zang Fu Connections	94
4. Three Layers of the Tongue	95
5. The Normal Tongue	96
6. Pale Tongue	97
7. Red Tongue	98
8. Red Points & Spots	99
9. Purple & Blue Tongue	100
10. Black & Gray Tongue	101
11. Thin Tongue	102
12. Swollen Tongue	103
13. Scalloped / Tooth-Marked Tongue	104
14. Cracks	105
15. Quivering, Moving & Deviated Tongue	106
16. Coating Color	107
17. Coating Thickness & Distribution	108
18. Coating Moisture	109
19. Coating Viscosity	110
20. Peeling & Rootless Coating	111
21. Sublingual Veins	112

PART ONE

Vital Substance Patterns

氣血津液精 — Qi · Blood · Fluids · Essence,
Deficiency & Excess

Deficiency, Stagnation, Stasis, and Excess patterns for each Vital Substance — the foundation everything after it builds on. 17 entries.

Qi Deficiency

氣虛 Qì Xū

PRESENTS AS

Slight shortness of breath, weak voice, spontaneous sweating, poor appetite, loose stools, tiredness (physical AND mental). Empty pulse.

ARISES FROM

More Qi consumed than the body can produce — overuse from illness, overwork, excessive sport/fitness training, excessive physical & mental activity, lack of sleep, or insufficient/poor-quality food. Most often involves Lung, Spleen, Kidney, Heart.

KEY DISCRIMINATOR

Fatigue is the hallmark, and it shows up both physically and mentally — not just tired muscles, a tired mind too.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Qi is the body's working capital. Spend faster than you earn it and the account runs low everywhere at once.

Sinking Qi

氣陷 Qì Xiàn

PRESENTS AS

Same base signs as Qi Deficiency, plus a feeling of bearing down, prolapse of an organ, mental depression, listlessness.

ARISES FROM

An aspect of Qi Deficiency specifically — not enough Yang Qi to rise and ascend. Spleen is the primary organ affected.

KEY DISCRIMINATOR

Qi Deficiency signs plus a literal 'things are falling' sensation (organ prolapse, bearing-down feeling) is Sinking, not plain Deficiency.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Qi normally holds things up against gravity. Deficient enough, and it stops fighting gravity altogether.

Qi Stagnation

氣滯 Qì Zhì

PRESENTS AS

Distention (subjective & objective), pain that moves and comes/goes with emotional state, mental depression, irritability, 'gloomy' feeling, frequent mood swings, frequent sighing, Wiry pulse, tongue normal or slightly red on the sides.

ARISES FROM

A common pathogenic factor, most often affecting the Liver (also Lungs, Heart, Stomach, Spleen, Intestines). Internal cause: emotional stress. Miscellaneous causes: irregular eating, excessive physical work, lack of exercise.

KEY DISCRIMINATOR

Distention outweighs pain, and both come and go with mood — that rhythm is the tell.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Think of Qi as traffic. Stagnation is a jam, not a closed road — pressure builds, eases, then builds again.

Rebellious Qi

氣逆 Qì Nì

ARISES FROM

Qi moving in the opposite of its normal physiological direction for that organ.

Organ	Normal	Pathological	Signs
Stomach	Downward	Upward	Belching, hiccup, nausea, vomiting
Spleen	Upward	Downward	Diarrhoea, prolapse
Liver	Upward	Excess up / horizontal / down	Headache, dizziness, irritability, nausea, vomiting, diarrhoea, dry stools, burning urination
Lungs	Downward	Upward	Cough, asthma
Kidneys	Downward	Upward	Asthma
Heart	Downward	Upward	Mental restlessness, insomnia

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Every organ's Qi has a commute route. Rebellious Qi is that commute running backwards — you can't diagnose it without knowing the NORMAL direction first.

Blood Deficiency

血虛 Xuè Xū

PRESENTS AS

Dull-white/sallow complexion, dizziness, poor memory, numbness/tingling, blurred vision, insomnia, pale lips, scanty periods or amenorrhoea, depression, slight anxiety, pale/thin/slightly dry tongue, Choppy or Fine pulse.

ARISES FROM

Inadequate intake of blood-rich foods, deficiency in blood-producing organs, blood loss via bleeding, consumption by excess mental or physical activity.

KEY DISCRIMINATOR

Signs cluster around dryness, pallor, and a mind that can't settle — insomnia, poor memory, anxiety are as diagnostic as the pale tongue.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Blood is Qi's cargo: nourishment, moisture, and a stable home for the mind. Run the cargo low and everything downstream turns dry and unsettled.

Blood Stasis — Overview

血瘀 Xuè Yū

PRESENTS AS

Stabbing/fixed/boring pain, dark complexion, purple lips/nails, bleeding with dark clots, dark menstrual blood with clots, fixed abdominal masses, Wiry/Choppy/Firm pulse, purple tongue.

ARISES FROM

Qi Stagnation, Qi Deficiency, Heat in the Blood, Blood Deficiency, Interior Cold, Dampness & Phlegm, Trauma, Emotions, Diet, Lifestyle habits.

KEY DISCRIMINATOR

FIXED and STABBING — location doesn't move and pressure doesn't relieve it, unlike Qi Stagnation's wandering, distending pain. Potentially the cause of serious disease: cancer, abdominal masses, fibroids, endometriosis, heart disease, stroke (Maciocia 2015).

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

If Qi Stagnation is a traffic jam, Blood Stasis is a stalled car blocking the lane entirely — same road, but now nothing moves through that exact spot.

Qi Stagnation vs. Blood Stasis

氣滯 vs 血瘀

Feature	Qi Stagnation	Blood Stasis
Pain/distension	More distension than pain	More pain than distension
Location	Moving	Fixed
Character	Distending pain	Boring, stabbing pain
Abdominal masses	Appearing and disappearing	Fixed
Skin	Not appearing on skin	May show purple blotches/bruises
Face	May be unchanged	Dark colour or bluish-green
Tongue	Normal or slightly red	Purple, especially on the sides
Pulse	Wiry	Wiry, Firm, or Choppy

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Same neighborhood, different problem. Qi Stagnation is pressure that moves; Blood Stasis is a fixed obstruction. The face and skin often tell you before the pulse does.

Blood Stasis — Liver & Heart

肝 · 心

PRESENTS AS

Liver: purple nails, dark face, painful periods with dark clots, abdominal pain, premenstrual pain, purple tongue (especially sides), Wiry or Firm pulse.

Heart: purple lips, stabbing/pricking chest pain, mental restlessness, purple tongue (sides toward front), purple/distended sublingual veins, Choppy or Knotted pulse.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Liver Blood Stasis shows up in the cycle and the belly.
Heart Blood Stasis shows up in the chest and under the tongue.

Blood Stasis — Lung, Stomach, Intestines & Uterus

肺 · 胃 · 腸 · 子宮

PRESENTS AS

Lung (Upper Burner): chest oppression, coughing dark blood, purple tongue sides toward front, distended sublingual veins.

Stomach (Middle Burner): epigastric pain, vomiting dark blood, dark blood in stools, tongue purple in the center.

Intestines (Lower Burner): dark blood in stools, severe abdominal pain, purple tongue at the rear.

Uterus (Lower Burner): painful periods, dark menstrual clots, amenorrhea, fixed abdominal masses.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Same purple-tongue, fixed-pain signature everywhere — only the tongue ZONE and the bleeding site change with the organ.

Heat in the Blood

血熱 Xuè Rè

PRESENTS AS

Feeling of heat, skin diseases with red eruptions, thirst, bleeding, red tongue, rapid pulse. **Heart:** anxiety, restlessness, mouth ulcers. **Liver:** itchy skin diseases with heat/redness. **Uterus:** excessive period blood loss. **Intestines:** blood in stools.

ARISES FROM

Invasion of Heat penetrating from exterior down to the Ying/Blood level (Four Levels), or internally generated from excess Heat in Liver or Heart.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Heat doesn't just warm Blood, it agitates it — pushing it out of its vessels (bleeding) and out through the skin (eruptions).

Loss of Blood

失血 Shī Xuè

PRESENTS AS

Bloody nose, vomiting blood, coughing up blood, blood in stool, menorrhagia, metrorrhagia, blood in urine.

ARISES FROM

Two main causes: (1) Qi Deficiency, unable to hold Blood in its vessels; (2) Blood Heat pushing Blood out of the vessels. Two less common causes: Blood Stasis, Yin Deficiency.

KEY DISCRIMINATOR

Ask WHY blood is escaping — a Deficient/holding problem (Qi) or a Heat/agitation problem (Heat) point to opposite treatment principles.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Blood needs two things to stay put: Qi to hold it in, and calm to keep it from being pushed out. Loss of Blood means one of those failed.

Deficiency of Body Fluids

津液虧虛

PRESENTS AS

Lung: dry skin, dry cough. **Stomach:** dry tongue with horizontal cracks, dry mouth without desire to drink (or small sips). **Kidney:** scanty urination, dry mouth at night, dry throat. **Large Intestine:** dry stool.

ARISES FROM

Associated with Yin — deficiency always causes dryness. Caused by dietary factors, Yin deficiency, heavy blood loss, profuse sweating, vomiting, diarrhea, or severe Blood deficiency.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Body Fluids are Yin's water supply. Deplete them and every organ that depends on moisture dries out in its own characteristic way.

Edema

水腫 Shuǐ Zhǒng

PRESENTS AS

Swelling from fluid retention outside the cells — fluid leaking from its normal pathways into the space between skin & muscles. **Pitting:** deficiency of Yang of Spleen, Lungs, and/or Kidneys. **Non-pitting:** Qi stagnation or Dampness.

ARISES FROM

By organ — Lung Yang deficiency: edema of face & hands. Spleen Yang deficiency: abdomen & limbs. Kidney Yang deficiency: lower body, legs & ankles.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Pitting edema is a Yang-power problem (not enough heat to move fluid). Non-pitting is a traffic problem (Qi or Damp blocking the road).

Phlegm — Substantial vs. Non-Substantial

痰 Tán

PRESENTS AS

Substantial: can be seen — e.g. sputum collected in the Lungs and spat out. **Non-substantial:** retained subcutaneously or in the channels; can obstruct Heart orifices or Gall Bladder/Kidneys (as stones); can settle in joints as arthritic bone deformities.

ARISES FROM

Spleen deficiency is the main cause; Lungs & Kidneys also involved (Lung fails to diffuse/lower fluids; Kidney fails to transform/excrete fluids).

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Substantial Phlegm is the Phlegm you can cough up. Non-substantial is the same mechanism hiding somewhere you can't see it — why it explains so many 'mystery' presentations.

Types of Substantial Phlegm

痰 — 有形

PRESENTS AS

Damp: profuse sticky white phlegm, chest/epigastric oppression, nausea, sticky taste, no thirst, Slippery pulse.

Heat: sticky yellow phlegm, red face, dry mouth, restlessness, Rapid-Slippery pulse.

Cold: white-watery phlegm, cold limbs, nausea, Deep-Slippery-Slow pulse.

Wind: unilateral numbness, rattling throat, aphasia, deviated tongue, Wiry pulse.

Fluid: very thin watery sputum, dizziness, Wiry pulse.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Same underlying Phlegm mechanism, five flavors depending on which pathogen rode along — color and consistency of what's coughed up is the fastest clue.

Types of Non-Substantial Phlegm

痰 — 無形

PRESENTS AS

Qi Phlegm: throat-swelling sensation (no visible swelling), difficulty swallowing, chest oppression, moodiness.

Under the Skin: lumps, swollen lymph nodes/thyroid, lipoma.

In the Channels: numbness.

Misting the Heart: mental illness.

Gallbladder & Kidneys: stones.

In the Joints: bone deformities in chronic rheumatoid arthritis.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

A throat lump, a lipoma, a stone, even some mental illness — all trace to the same invisible Phlegm, just settling in a different location each time.

Essence (Jing) Deficiency

精虛 Jīng Xū

PRESENTS AS

In children: poor bone development, late closure of fontanelle, mental dullness/retardation.

In adults: softening of bones, weakness of knees & legs, lower backache, poor memory, loose teeth, falling hair or premature greying, weakness of sexual activity, infertility, sterility, tinnitus, deafness, absent-mindedness, decreased mental sharpness.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Jing is the fixed capital you were born with. Deficiency in a child looks like development that never fully switches on; in an adult it looks like premature aging.

PART TWO

Eight Principles

八纲 Bā Gāng — 表里 · 寒热 · 虚实 · 阴阳

Four axes, not eight boxes. Every patient sits somewhere on each of: Exterior/Interior (where) · Cold/Heat (nature) · Deficiency/Excess (strength) · Yin/Yang (the summary of the other three).

Axis	Fastest Test
Exterior / Interior	Simultaneous chills AND fever + Floating pulse = Exterior
Cold / Heat	Thirst, drink preference, urine colour, tongue coat
Deficiency / Excess	Pressure: relieved = Deficiency · aggravated = Excess
Yin / Yang	Read off the other three

Schrier's formulas: Yang def = Qi deficiency signs + cold. Yin def = Blood deficiency signs + heat.

Exterior

表 Biǎo

PRESENTS AS

Aversion to cold and fever occurring TOGETHER, aching body, stiff neck, Floating pulse. Sudden onset, short duration, early stage.

ARISES FROM

Invasion of the superficial portion of the body by an exogenous pathogen.

Key discriminator

The pairing is everything. The moment the aversion to cold disappears while fever persists, the pathogen has moved Interior.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Think of the body as a walled city under attack from outside. Fighting at the wall makes you feel both the cold outside and the heat of the battle at once — that simultaneity is the whole diagnosis.

Kaptchuk · Maciocia

Interior

里 Lǐ

PRESENTS AS

No simultaneous aversion to cold, Deep pulse. Located in the five Zang and six Fu.

ARISES FROM

Either an exterior pathogen transmitted inward, or functional disturbance of the Zang-Fu themselves.

Key discriminator

Interior also tells you the DIRECTION of travel. Exterior → Interior means the disease is advancing.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Exterior/Interior isn't strictly anatomical depth — it's a statement about where the fight is happening and which way it's moving.

Maciocia

Exterior Cold

表寒

PRESENTS AS

Slight fever, pronounced aversion to cold, severe body aches, severe stiff neck, NO sweating, no thirst. Floating-Tight pulse, thin white coating.

ARISES FROM

Wind-Cold invasion.

Key discriminator

No sweating plus severe aches is the Full Exterior picture.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Cold contracts. The pores shut (no sweat), the muscles seize (severe aches), the vessel tightens (Tight pulse). One mechanism, three signs.

Kaptchuk

Exterior Heat

表热

PRESENTS AS

Fever, mild aversion to cold, sore throat, thirst. Floating-Rapid pulse.

ARISES FROM

Wind-Heat invasion.

Key discriminator

Sore throat is the reliable early differentiator from Exterior Cold.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Heat rises and disperses — so it shows first at the top and outside: throat, head, skin.

Maciocia

Full Exterior

表实

PRESENTS AS

Fever, NO sweating, severe body aches, aversion to cold. Floating-Tight pulse, thin white coating.

ARISES FROM

Strong pathogen meeting strong Zheng Qi.

Key discriminator

No sweating = Full.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

The gate is shut and both armies are strong. Nothing is leaking out.

Maciocia

Empty Exterior

表虚

PRESENTS AS

Slight or NO fever, sweating present, aversion to WIND, slight body aches.
Floating-Slow pulse, thin white coating.

ARISES FROM

Weak Wei Qi failing to secure the exterior.

Key discriminator

Sweating plus aversion to wind rather than cold.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

The gate won't close. Sweat escapes, and moving air feels intolerable because there's no defence at the surface.

Maciocia

Full Cold

实寒

PRESENTS AS

Feeling cold, cold limbs, no thirst, pale face, abdominal pain
AGGRAVATED by pressure, desire for warm drinks, loose stools, clear abundant urine. Deep-Full-Tight pulse, Pale tongue with THICK white coating.

ARISES FROM

Excess of Yin. Cold foods, iced drinks, or external Cold penetrating inward.

Key discriminator

Face bright-white · pain sharp and worse on pressure · better after a bowel movement.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Something is physically there and obstructing — that's why pressure hurts. Excess always resents pressure.

Maciocia FCM Table 30.2

Empty Cold

虚寒

PRESENTS AS

Feeling cold, cold limbs, DULL pale face, no thirst, listlessness, sweating, loose stools, clear abundant urine. Deep-Slow or Weak pulse, Pale tongue with THIN white coating.

ARISES FROM

Deficiency of Yang. Overwork, inadequate warm food, excessive sexual activity, internal Cold injuring Yang.

Key discriminator

Face dull-white · pain dull and BETTER on pressure · worse after a bowel movement.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Nothing is there to obstruct — the problem is absence. Pressure adds the support that's missing, so it helps.

Maciocia FCM Table 30.2

Full Heat

实热

PRESENTS AS

Thirst, feeling of heat, mental restlessness, RED FACE (whole face), dry stools, scanty dark urine. Rapid-Full pulse, Red tongue with YELLOW coating.

ARISES FROM

Excess Yang. Emotional problems; diet (red meat, spices, alcohol); an exterior pathogen penetrating inward and transforming to Heat.

Key discriminator

High fever · very restless and agitated · profuse sweating · loud voice · thirst for cold drinks.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

A fire with fuel. Loud, red, dry, and outward. Everything about it is additive.

Maciocia

Empty Heat

虚热

PRESENTS AS

Heat in the afternoon or evening, dry mouth wanting small sips, dry throat AT NIGHT, night sweating, five-palm heat (chest, palms, soles), dry stools, scanty dark urine. Floating-Empty-Rapid pulse, Red tongue with NO coating.

ARISES FROM

Deficiency of Yin — Yin consumed over time, leaving Yang relatively in excess. Overwork, irregular eating, excessive sexual activity, heavy blood loss.

Key discriminator

MALAR FLUSH only, not whole face · low-grade afternoon fever · vague anxiety · thin red tongue, NO coating.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Not a bigger fire — a smaller pond. The heat is relative, which is why it's timed (afternoon, night) rather than constant.

Maciocia

Full / Excess

实 Shí

PRESENTS AS

Pain AGGRAVATED by pressure, forceful pulse, loud voice, robust build, agitation, thick tongue coating.

ARISES FROM

A pathogenic factor is present and the body's Qi is still strong enough to fight it.

Key discriminator

Pressure response is the single fastest differentiator in the entire Eight Principles.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Excess = something present that shouldn't be. Deficiency = something absent that should be. Press: if it hurts more, something is there.

Kaptchuk · Maciocia

Empty / Deficiency

虚 Xū

PRESENTS AS

Pain RELIEVED by pressure and warmth, weak pulse, quiet voice, fatigue, thin or no coating.

ARISES FROM

The body's own Qi, Blood, Yin, or Yang is insufficient.

Key discriminator

Deficiency likes pressure. Excess resents it.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Same test, opposite answer. It works because you're asking whether adding is welcome or unwelcome.

Kaptchuk

Yin Pattern

阴 Yīn

PRESENTS AS

Groups Interior + Cold + Deficiency. Quiet, slow, pale, cold, withdrawn, weak pulse.

ARISES FROM

The master category — everything Yin-natured collapses into it.

Key discriminator

If you can place a patient on the other three pairs, Yin/Yang is already decided.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Yin/Yang isn't a fourth independent question — it's the summary of the first three.

Kaptchuk

Yang Pattern

阳 Yáng

PRESENTS AS

Groups Exterior + Heat + Excess. Loud, fast, red, hot, agitated, forceful pulse.

ARISES FROM

The master category for everything Yang-natured.

Key discriminator

Yang = faster, louder, more active. Yin = slower, quieter, less.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Use it as a sanity check: if you've called something Interior-Cold-Deficient, it should read as Yin overall. If it doesn't, re-examine.

Kaptchuk

False Heat, True Cold

真寒假热

PRESENTS AS

Red cheeks but the colour is POWDER-LIKE and the rest of the face is white; irritability but also listlessness; wants to lie curled up; thirst but NO desire to drink, or wants WARM fluids; body feels hot but the patient wants to be COVERED; sore throat without redness or swelling; pale urine; quiet breathing, low voice. Pale wet tongue. Pulse Rapid, Floating, Big but EMPTY.

ARISES FROM

Interior Cold forcing the remaining Yang outward and upward.

Key discriminator

This is NOT Empty-Heat. In Empty-Heat there really is Heat. Here the Heat appearance is false — there is no Heat at all.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

A dying fire flaring at the edges. The flare looks like heat but the hearth is cold. Ask about drinks and covers — the patient's own preference gives it away.

Maciocia · Kaptchuk

False Cold, True Heat

真热假寒

PRESENTS AS

Dark face with BRIGHT eyes and 'spirit'; red-dry lips; irritability with a strong body; thirst WITH desire for cold fluids; scanty dark urine; constipation; burning in the anus; noisy breathing, loud voice. Red-dry tongue body. Pulse Deep and FULL — cold limbs but the CHEST IS HOT.

ARISES FROM

Full Heat so intense it drives Yang inward and away from the extremities.

Key discriminator

Cold limbs but a hot chest. Feel the chest, not just the hands.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

The furnace is roaring but the doors are shut, so the outside feels cool. Everything central — voice, eyes, thirst, urine — reports the real state.

Maciocia · Kaptchuk

Cold Exterior, Heat Interior

表寒里热

PRESENTS AS

Fever with aversion to cold, no sweating, headache and stiff neck, body aches (exterior Cold) PLUS irritability and thirst (interior Heat).

ARISES FROM

Pre-existing interior Heat, then invaded by exterior Wind-Cold.

Key discriminator

Both pictures are genuinely present — this is not a false appearance.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Two real problems stacked, not one problem in disguise. Treat both.

Maciocia

Heat Exterior, Cold Interior

表热里寒

PRESENTS AS

Fever with aversion to cold, sore throat, thirst, headache, Floating-Rapid pulse PLUS loose stools, chilliness, profuse pale urine.

ARISES FROM

Pre-existing Cold condition, then attacked by exterior Wind-Heat.

Key discriminator

Upper/outer Heat signs with lower/inner Cold signs.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Mirror image of the above. Again both are real.

Maciocia

Heat Above, Cold Below

上热下寒

PRESENTS AS

Above: thirst, irritability, sour regurgitation, bitter taste, mouth ulcers.

Below: loose stools, borborygmi, profuse pale urine.

ARISES FROM

Heat rises, Cold descends — they separate rather than mixing.

Key discriminator

Mouth ulcers with loose stools is the classic pairing.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Heat naturally goes up and Cold naturally goes down, so when both exist they stratify. The body layers rather than averages.

Maciocia

Combined Heat and Cold

寒热错杂

PRESENTS AS

Manifestations of both simply coexisting.

ARISES FROM

Extremely common in practice — e.g. Kidney-Yang deficiency with Damp-Heat in the Bladder, or Spleen-Yang deficiency with Liver-Fire.

Key discriminator

Don't force a single label. Real patients are frequently both.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

The Eight Principles are axes, not boxes. A patient occupies a position on each one independently.

Kaptchuk

PART THREE

Pulse Diagnosis

脈診 Mài Zhěn — Components & The 28 Qualities

Before You Palpate

Do	Why
Ask permission, every time	Non-negotiable — and it settles them
Arm horizontal, not above heart level	Bends impede flow
Index=Cùn, middle=Guān, ring=Chǐ	Middle finger always on Guān
All three fingers down first	Overall impression before positions
Your right hand → their left wrist	Reverse if seated same-side
Let them settle	Stairs, cold, a heavy meal all move the pulse
Note time and season	Both shift the pulse independent of pathology
Count against YOUR breath	Breathe naturally — don't engineer it

*Fingers are not held still. Still only when counting rate.
Otherwise press/lift for depth, roll for length, push medial-lateral for shape.*

Width

DEFINES

The diameter of the vessel, dependent on Qi and Blood.
Normal width is moderate — neither too thin nor too wide.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

A too-thin pulse under your fingers is already telling you something before you've assessed a single quality — width alone can flag Deficiency.

Depth

DEFINES

The level at which the pulse is felt most strongly. Normal pulse is felt best at the MIDDLE depth — showing Qi and Blood flow freely between interior and exterior.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

This is the baseline every Floating/Deep assessment is measured against — know what 'middle' actually feels like before you can call something Floating or Deep.

Rate

DEFINES

Number of beats per minute. Normal is 4–5 beats per respiratory cycle (one breath), roughly 60–90 bpm. Rate reflects the state of Yang.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Counted against the PRACTITIONER's breath, not the patient's — your own breathing is the more stable reference point.

Rhythm

DEFINES

The pattern of the beats. Normal pulse beats with a regular rhythm, closely tied to Heart Qi commanding Blood through the vessels.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

This is what Knotted, Hasty, and Intermittent pulses all disrupt in different ways — know regular first, or the irregulars won't stand out.

Length

DEFINES

The length in relation to the three positions. Normal pulse is felt at all three positions, neither long nor short. Qi plays the major role in pulse length.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

A pulse that spills past its position or falls short of one tells you about Qi's reach before you even name a quality.

Tension

DEFINES

How taut or slack the vessel feels. Normal pulse is neither too taut nor too slack — tension mainly reflects the condition of Qi and Blood.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

This is the axis Wiry and Tight both live on — tension is the raw material both qualities are built from.

Shape

DEFINES

The wave/contour as the pulse rises and falls. Beat has two parts — ascending and descending. In a normal pulse, the two are roughly equal.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

An uneven rise-vs-fall is often the first physical clue something's off, even before you can name which quality you're feeling.

Strength

DEFINES

The beating force beneath the finger. Normal beat is moderate strength, gentle and soft — neither forceful nor weak.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Strength is the axis Full and Empty are built from — the most load-bearing of all eight components for Bā Gāng crossover.

Three depths

Depth	How to find it	Reflects
Superficial	Light contact, just the skin	Qi
Middle	Press to bone, obliterate, release <i>slowly</i>	Blood
Deep	Press to bone level	Yin organs

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

The middle is the one everyone skips because it has no landmark. Find your two anchors first — surface and bone — then travel slowly between them. The middle announces itself as a change, not as a place.

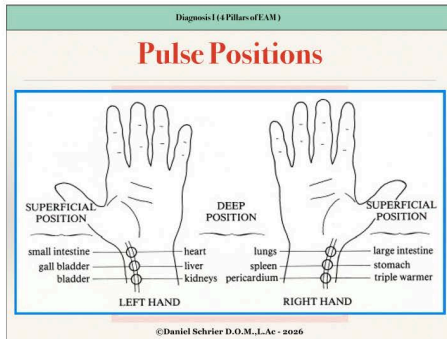
Maciocia · Shen Hammer

Six positions — Nan Jing

	Left	Right
寸 Cùn Upper Burner	Hand Taiyang / SI · Hand Shaoyin / HT	Hand Yangming / LI · Hand Taiyin / LU
關 Guān Middle Burner	Foot Shaoyang / GB · Foot Jueyin / LR	Foot Yangming / ST · Foot Taiyin / SP
尺 Chǐ Lower Burner	Foot Taiyang / BL · Foot Shaoyin / KD	Hand Shaoyang / TB · Hand Jueyin / PC

Quick: L = HT · LR · KD | R = LU · SP · PC

Pulse Positions & the Three Depths



Nan Jing system, straight from the lecture slide. Each Zang pairs with a Fu at the same position — e.g. Left Cun is Heart AND Small Intestine together. Right Chi is the position most schools disagree on: the Nan Jing's own answer is Pericardium/San Jiao, linked to Kidney only through Ming Men theory. The Su Wen instead reads pulses at nine separate body locations, not the wrist alone.

Three Depths, Every Position

Superficial (Qi/Yang layer) · Middle · Deep (Blood/Yin layer). Six positions, three depths each — 18 readings total.

Normal & seasonal

胃神根	Means
胃 Wèi	Flowing, gentle, harmonious movement
神 Shén	Strong, rhythmical — vitality present in the beat
根 Gēn	Depth felt at Chǐ — Kidney Qi intact under firm pressure

Rate: 4–5 beats per your breath, 60–90 bpm.

Season	Pulse	Dates
Spring	Wiry 弦	Feb 4 – May 4
Summer	Flooding 洪	May 5 – Aug 6
Autumn	Hair-like / Floating 毛	Aug 7 – Nov 6
Winter	Stone / Deep 石	Nov 7 – Feb 3

Seasonal ≠ normal automatically. Only when nothing else corroborates pathology. Flooding in *winter* is a warning — Schrier's case ended in a fatal cerebral hemorrhage.

Floating 浮 Fú

FEEL

Felt distinctly at the superficial depth; force decreases slightly deeper but never feels empty.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

Wood floating on water; a subtle breeze across a bird's back; scallion leaves rolled lightly between the fingers.

INDICATES

Invasion of external Wind. Yin Deficiency (interior condition presenting superficially).

NOT TO BE CONFUSED WITH

vs Yin Deficiency: Exterior needs simultaneous chills AND fever.

COMBINATIONS

Floating-Weak: External-Empty, weak Wei Qi failing to react to invasion. Floating-Empty: Summer-Heat (floats more) vs Yin Deficiency (floats less), degree is the differentiator. Floating-Slippery: Wind-Damp, or Wind complicated by Phlegm.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Put a ping-pong ball in water and press it: it rises to meet your finger, dips when pushed, springs back the moment you ease off. It comes UP to meet you rather than sitting under your finger.

Then what: chills and fever together, stiff neck, stuffy nose? Exterior. Night sweats, hot palms/soles, a flushed cheek patch, dry throat at night? Yin Deficiency wearing the same costume.

Maciocia · Kaptchuk

Deep / Submerged

沉 Chén

FEEL

Located deep next to the bone; barely felt with light or moderate pressure; only felt pressing to bone and tendons.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

A stone thrown into a well, sinking to the bottom.

INDICATES

Pathogenic factor in the Interior (Deep-Full). Yang Deficiency (Deep-Weak).

Not to be confused with

vs **Hidden**: Hidden can't be found until bone-level pressure.

COMBINATIONS

Deep-Weak — Yang Deficiency

Deep-Wiry — Blood Stasis, or a Chong Mai issue

Deep-Wiry-Slow — Blood stasis due to Cold, or Cold stagnating in the Liver channel

Deep-Slow — interior Cold

Deep-Rapid — interior Heat

Deep-Soggy-Slow — Dampness in the Interior

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Nothing at all on light touch — beginners often conclude there's no pulse. Keep pressing toward the bone and it appears. Like feeling for a stone at the bottom of a pond.

Then what

Once you've found it, ask whether it's strong or weak down there. Deep + forceful = a pathogen sitting in the Interior. Deep + feeble = Yang Deficiency. Same depth, opposite treatment.

Maciocia

Slow

遲 *Chí*

FEEL

Fewer than three beats per breath, about 40–60bpm, regular rhythm.

INDICATES

Cold pattern. Empty-Cold (Slow+Weak). Full-Cold (Slow+Full).

Not to be confused with

vs **Huǎn**: Slow is under 3/breath. Huǎn is 4 — and healthy.

COMBINATIONS

Slow-Floating — exterior Wind-Cold with prevalence of Wind

Slow-Deep — interior Cold

Slow-Slippy — Cold-Phlegm or Damp-Cold

Slow-Choppy — Blood Deficiency and interior Cold

Slow-Weak — Empty-Cold with Yang Deficiency

Slow-Full — internal Cold, often chronic painful conditions

Slow-Wiry — stagnation of Cold in the Liver channel

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Not dramatic — just unhurried. You'll notice you're waiting between beats while breathing normally.

Then what

COUNT IT. Under 3 per breath is Slow. Four is Huǎn, which is healthy. This single count is the most common careless error in the whole unit.

Maciocia

Rapid

數 Shuò

FEEL

Over five beats per breath, 90–140bpm, regular rhythm.

INDICATES

Heat pattern. Full-Heat (Rapid+Full). Empty-Heat (Rapid+Floating-Empty).

COMBINATIONS

Rapid-Full — Full-Heat from Excess of Yang

Rapid-Empty — Empty-Heat from Deficiency of Yin

Rapid-Fine / Rapid-Floating — External Wind-Heat

Rapid-Deep — interior Heat

Rapid-Overflowing — Full-Heat

Rapid-Wiry — Liver-Fire

Rapid-Slippery — Phlegm-Heat

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

It feels busy. You can't finish a comfortable breath before five or more beats have gone by.

Then what

Before calling it Heat, ask whether they rushed in, climbed stairs, or are anxious. Settle them two minutes and re-take. Exertion produces a rapid pulse that means nothing.

Maciocia

Empty / Deficient

虛 Xū

FEEL

Wide but without strength; forceless at all three positions under light or heavy pressure; a sense of emptiness.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

A water balloon — big on the outside, nothing solid when you press in.

INDICATES

Qi Deficiency.

Not to be confused with

vs **Scattered**: Empty keeps its shape; Scattered loses it and can't be counted.

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

A water balloon. Wide across, but press in and nothing solid pushes back. The vessel is broad and the content isn't filling it.

Then what

Confirm with the person, not the wrist: tired? short of breath? quiet voice? Does pressure on a sore spot feel GOOD? Deficiency welcomes pressure.

Schrier · Maciocia

Full / Excessive

實 Shí

FEEL

Felt at all three positions and all three depths; long, wide, and forceful.

INDICATES

Full pattern. Full-Heat (Full+Rapid). Full-Cold (Full+Slow).

Not to be confused with

vs **Overflowing**: Full does not decay.

COMBINATIONS

Full-Rapid — Full-Heat

Full-Slow — Full-Cold

Full-Tight — Full-Cold

Full-Slippery — Phlegm

Full-Long — Heat

Full-Wiry — Full Liver pattern

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

It meets you everywhere — light, medium, deep, all three positions, pushing back at every one.

Then what

Ask whether pressure makes anything worse. Excess resents pressure. Then decide Heat or Cold: thirst and dark urine, or cold limbs and clear urine.

Maciocia

Slippery

滑 Huá

FEEL

Feels quick though not rapid; slippery and smooth; rounded inside the vessel, as if oily.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

A pearl rolling on a plate; a raindrop gliding off a leaf.

INDICATES

Phlegm. Dampness. Retention of food. Pregnancy.

Not to be confused with

vs **Moving**: Slippery glides throughout; Moving bounces at one point.

COMBINATIONS

Slippery-Floating — Wind-Phlegm

Slippery-Rapid — Damp-Heat or Phlegm-Heat

Slippery-Slow — Damp-Cold or Cold-Phlegm

Slippery-Big — Phlegm-Heat with predominance of Heat

Slippery-Short — Dampness or Phlegm with Qi Deficiency

Slippery-Weak — Dampness or Phlegm with Qi Deficiency

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

A wet grape or a ball bearing rolling under your fingertip. Smooth, rounded, faintly oily — it slides rather than bumps.

Then what

Ask about heaviness, muzzy-headedness, appetite, and recent meals. If relevant, ask "are you trying to conceive?" — never "are you pregnant?"

Maciocia · Deadman

Choppy

湖
波 Sè

FEEL

Seems slow and is not smooth; vessel is thin; rhythm irregular in force and fullness; feels rough, jagged.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

Scraping bamboo with a small knife.

INDICATES

Blood Deficiency. Exhaustion of Body Fluids.

Not to be confused with

vs **Fine**: Choppy is rough and uneven; Fine is smooth, merely narrow.

COMBINATIONS

Choppy-Weak — depletion of both Qi and Blood

Choppy-Minute — extreme Blood Deficiency

Choppy-Soggy — Qi and Blood Deficiency with some Dampness

Choppy-Floating — invasion of external Wind

Choppy-Deep — longstanding Blood Deficiency

Choppy-Full — Blood Stasis (potentially)

Choppy-Knotted — Blood Stasis from Yang Deficiency and internal Cold

Choppy-Fine — Deficiency of Body Fluids

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Drag a fingernail across corduroy, or a small blade across bamboo. It catches and releases, uneven in force beat to beat. The exact opposite sensation to Slippery.

Then what

Look for Blood Deficiency signs: pale lips, dizziness on standing, poor memory, scanty periods. If instead you find fixed stabbing pain and purple lips, you're looking at Blood Stasis.

Long

長 Cháng

FEEL

Smooth and straight; felt extending distally and proximally beyond the usual positions.

INDICATES

Heat patterns.

COMBINATIONS

Long-Rapid — internal Heat

Long-Floating — external Wind-Heat

Long-Deep — internal Heat

Long-Wiry — Liver disharmony (usually excess)

Long-Slippery — Phlegm-Heat

Long-Overflowing — excess of Yang and Heat

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

It runs past where you expect it to stop — extending beyond the three finger positions in one or both directions.

Then what

Long usually means something is expanding outward: Heat, or Liver-Yang rising. Check for irritability, headache, red face.

Maciocia

Short

短 Duǎn

FEEL

Cannot be felt in all three positions; absent at the distal and/or proximal position.

INDICATES

Severe Qi Deficiency. Stomach-Qi Deficiency.

COMBINATIONS

Short-Floating — Lung-Qi Deficiency

Short-Choppy — Heart-Qi Deficiency

Short-Rapid — severe Heart-Blood Deficiency with Empty-Heat

Short-Slow — Yang Deficiency with internal Cold

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

The reverse — it doesn't fill the span. One of your three fingers finds nothing while the others do.

Then what

Note WHICH finger comes up empty. Missing at the front (Cùn) points somewhere different from missing at the rear (Chǐ).

Maciocia

Overflowing / Flooding

洪 Hóng

FEEL

Wide and forceful, though it fades gently; vessel wide and thick.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

Ocean waves that come strongly but leave calmly.

INDICATES

Full-Heat. Empty-Heat (Overflowing-Empty).

Not to be confused with

vs **Full**: Overflowing fades gently; Full is uniform at every depth.

COMBINATIONS

Overflowing-Floating — Wind-Heat with intense Heat — can progress quickly to the Qi level

Overflowing-Deep — internal Heat

Overflowing-Slippery — Phlegm-Heat with prevalence of Heat

Overflowing-Soft — Yin Deficiency with exhaustion of Body Fluids and Empty-Heat

Overflowing-Tight — Painful Obstruction (Bi) Syndrome

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

A wave that arrives with real force and then recedes gently. Strong arrival, soft departure. That asymmetry is what separates it from Full.

Then what

Check the calendar. In summer this may be entirely normal. In WINTER it is a warning sign and you should not wave it away.

Maciocia · Kaptchuk

Fine / Thin

細 Xì

FEEL

Very thin, like a fine thread, but distinct and clear without interruption of rhythm under pressure.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

Angel-hair pasta rather than a thick udon noodle.

INDICATES

Blood Deficiency. Dampness with severe Qi Deficiency.

Not to be confused with

vs **Minute**: Fine stays clear and continuous. Minute fades in and out.

COMBINATIONS

Fine-Rapid — Yin Deficiency with Empty-Heat

Fine-Wiry — Liver-Qi Stagnation

Fine-Tight — Empty-Cold with underlying Blood Deficiency

Fine-Choppy — severe Blood or Essence Deficiency

Fine-Weak — severe Blood Deficiency

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Angel-hair pasta rather than udon. Narrow, but perfectly clear and continuous — you can trace it without losing it.

Then what

Thin means not enough substance filling the vessel — think Blood. Add Rapid to it and you have Yin Deficiency with Empty-Heat.

Schrier · Maciocia

Minute / Faint

微 Wēi

FEEL

Extremely thin and forceless; seems felt, then not felt; pressing deeply the vessel becomes vague.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

Now you see it, now you don't.

INDICATES

Severe deficiency of Qi and Blood.

Not to be confused with

vs **Fine**: Minute is thin AND forceless.

COMBINATIONS

Minute-Rapid — Yin Deficiency with Empty-Heat

Minute-Slow — severe Qi & Blood Deficiency with internal Cold

Minute-Choppy — exhaustion of Blood

Minute-Soggy — Qi & Blood Deficiency with Dampness

Minute-Wiry — Liver-Yang rising with underlying Blood Deficiency

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

There, then not there. You catch it, lose it, catch it again. Thin AND weak — the combination is what makes it Minute rather than Fine.

Then what

This is a depletion finding, not a subtle one. Take it seriously and look at the whole person.

Maciocia

Tight

緊 Jǐn

FEEL

Rises and falls with strength, vibrating left and right; feels twisted like a thick rope.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

Fingers on a highly stretched twisted cord, snapping back and forth.

INDICATES

Cold — Exterior (Tight-Floating), Interior Full-Cold (Tight-Full-Deep), Interior Empty-Cold (Tight-Weak-Deep). Pain.

Not to be confused with

vs **Wiry**: Tight snaps side to side; Wiry holds a straight line.

COMBINATIONS

Tight-Floating — Wind-Cold invasion, prevalence of Cold

Tight-Deep — internal Full-Cold

Tight-Choppy — Cold Bi Syndrome

Tight-Slippery — Cold-Phlegm

Tight-Firm — Blood Stasis from Cold

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

A rope being twisted under your fingers — it doesn't just push up, it snaps side to side. A rubber band pulled taut and plucked.

Then what

Tight means Cold or pain. Ask where it hurts, and whether warmth helps. Cold contracts: shut pores, seized muscles, tight vessel — one mechanism, three signs.

Maciocia

Wiry

弦 Xián

FEEL

Taut, long, and forceful whether pressed or not; maintains a straight line beneath the fingers.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

A spring stretched on a musical instrument; a guitar string about to snap.

INDICATES

Liver disharmony. Pain. Phlegm.

Not to be confused with

vs **Tight**: Wiry is a stable line. Also normal in Spring.

COMBINATIONS

Wiry-Rapid — Liver-Fire

Wiry-Slow — stagnation of Cold in the Liver channel

Wiry-Long — Liver-Qi Stagnation or Liver-Blood Stasis

Wiry-Tight — Blood Stasis

Wiry-Big — Liver-Fire or Liver-Yang rising

Wiry-Overflowing — Liver-Fire

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

A guitar or bowstring. Straight, taut, and it HOLDS that line — no lateral wobble. Press harder and it stays a line.

Then what

Ask about stress, frustration, sighing, tension under the ribs. But check the season first — Wiry is normal in spring if nothing else corroborates.

Schrier · Maciocia

Slowed-Down / Moderate

緩 Huǎn

FEEL

Beats four times per breath — faster than the Slow pulse.

INDICATES

Generally a HEALTHY pulse — the one qualitatively normal entry on this list.

Not to be confused with

vs **Slow**: Huǎn is 4/breath and normal. Slow is under 3 and means Cold.

COMBINATIONS

Slowed-Down-Soggy — Dampness with Spleen-Qi Deficiency

Slowed-Down-Slippery — Cold-Dampness

Slowed-Down-Fine — Qi and Blood Deficiency

Slowed-Down-Floating — weakness of the Wei Qi

Slowed-Down-Deep — weakness of the Ying Qi

Slowed-Down-Choppy — Blood Deficiency

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Relaxed and even. Nothing draws attention to itself. If your reaction is "this seems fine," that reaction is probably correct.

Then what

This is the one healthy pulse among the 28. Count to confirm — 4 per breath. Then stop looking for pathology that isn't there.

Maciocia

Hollow

芤 Kōu

FEEL

Wide and soft when touched lightly, hollow when seeking; edges clearly felt under pressure but the center is obscure.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

A scallion stalk — has an edge but is hollow inside.

INDICATES

Hemorrhage. Forthcoming hemorrhage (Hollow+Rapid). Yin Deficiency.

Not to be confused with

vs **Leather**: Hollow is soft at the surface; Leather is forceful there.

COMBINATIONS

Hollow-Rapid — Yin Deficiency with Empty-Heat, or impending hemorrhage

Hollow-Empty-Soggy — loss of Essence or depletion of Blood

Hollow-Knotted — Yang Deficiency or Blood Stasis

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Press the flat of a scallion, or a drinking straw. You feel the walls clearly on either side and emptiness in the middle. Present at the surface, present deep, absent between.

Then what

Ask directly about blood loss — heavy periods, recent injury, surgery, childbirth. Hollow plus Rapid can signal bleeding that hasn't happened yet.

Maciocia

Leather

革 Gé

FEEL

Large, thick, and wide; rapid and forceful when lightly touched, but hollow when pressed deeply.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

The surface of a drum — thick on top, hollow beneath.

INDICATES

Severe Kidney-Essence Deficiency. Severe Kidney-Yin Deficiency.

Not to be confused with

vs **Hollow**: both hollow beneath — Leather meets you with force first.

COMBINATIONS

Leather-Rapid — severe Deficiency of Yin with Empty-Heat

Leather-Slow — severe Blood Deficiency with Blood Stasis

Leather-Choppy — severe Blood Deficiency

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

A drum head. Taut and forceful on top, nothing underneath. Where Hollow is soft at the surface, Leather meets you firmly first.

Then what

This points to deep Essence or Yin depletion — usually long-standing, often following major loss. Not a same-week finding.

Maciocia

Firm / Confined

牢 Láo

FEEL

Deep, taut, long, wide, and forceful; deeply located, cannot be felt with light or moderate pressure.

INDICATES

Blood Stasis. Interior Cold (Firm+Slow). Pain.

Not to be confused with

vs **Deep**: Firm adds taut, long, wide and forceful.

COMBINATIONS

Firm-Tight — internal Cold

Firm-Slow — internal Cold and Blood Stasis

Firm-Choppy — Blood Stasis

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Deep like a stone, but a stone with tension in it — long, wide, and forceful once you reach it.

Then what

Look for fixed masses, fixed pain, or long-standing Cold. Firm is Deep with attitude.

Maciocia

Soggy

濡 RÚ

FEEL

Superficial, thin, and forceless; grows weaker and weaker the more it is pressed.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

A strand of cotton floating on water; a bubble that bursts under light pressure.

INDICATES

Dampness with Qi Deficiency. Yin Deficiency. Essence Deficiency.

Not to be confused with

vs **Weak**: Soggy floats; Weak sits deep.

COMBINATIONS

Soggy-Fine — severe Spleen-Qi Deficiency

Soggy-Choppy — exhaustion of Blood

Soggy-Floating — Deficiency of Wei Qi with Dampness

Soggy-Wiry — Dampness with Liver-Qi Stagnation

Soggy-Rapid — Damp-Heat

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Wet cotton wool floating on water, or a soap bubble. It's up at the surface, but the harder you press the more it dissolves.

Then what

Damp plus weakness. Ask about heaviness in the limbs, foggy thinking, loose stools, and whether damp weather makes it worse.

Maciocio

Weak / Frail

弱 Ruò

FEEL

Forceless, deep, and thin; only felt at the deep level by pressing; lost entirely with more pressure.

INDICATES

Yang Deficiency. Blood Deficiency.

Not to be confused with

vs **Soggy**: Weak is deep; Soggy is superficial.

COMBINATIONS

Weak-Choppy — Blood Deficiency

Weak-Fine — severe Blood Deficiency

Weak-Slow — Yang Deficiency

Weak-Soggy — Yang Deficiency with some Dampness

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Deep and yielding. You have to press to find it, and pressing further loses it entirely.

Then what

Yang or Blood is short. Ask about cold, fatigue, and whether they feel worse in the morning or after exertion.

Maciocia

Scattered

散 Sǎn

FEEL

Wide, superficial, forceless, and slack when touched lightly; indistinct; disappears under pressure, rate hard to count.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

Flower blossoms lightly scattering to the ground.

INDICATES

Severe Qi and Blood Deficiency. Severe Kidney–Qi Deficiency. A serious condition.

Not to be confused with

vs **Empty**: if you cannot count the rate, it is Scattered. Serious.

COMBINATIONS

Scattered–Slow — severe Qi and Yang Deficiency

Scattered–Rapid — severe Blood Deficiency with Empty–Heat

Scattered–Floating — severe Deficiency of Yuan Qi with floating of Yang, or with Yin Fire

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

It has no edges. You can't say where it starts or stops, and you genuinely cannot count it. A dandelion seed-head in wind.

Then what

If you cannot count the rate, stop and take the whole picture seriously. This is a depletion finding that warrants escalation, not a subtle variant.

Maciocia · Kaptchuk

Hidden

伏 Fú

FEEL

Cannot be felt touching, seeking, or pressing — only felt pressing very heavily to the bone.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

Pulsation seeming to come from beneath the bone and tendons.

INDICATES

Severe Yang Deficiency.

Not to be confused with

vs **Deep**: Deep is findable with firm pressure; Hidden is not.

COMBINATIONS

Hidden-Full — Qi and Blood stagnation; retention of food; internal Cold; internal Heat

Hidden-Empty — severe Yang Deficiency with internal Cold

Hidden-Rapid — interior Heat

Hidden-Slow — interior Cold

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Absent through light, medium, and deep. Only bone-level pressure finds anything. Beginners routinely mistake this for their own technique failing.

Then what

Before concluding Hidden, check your hand position and pressure. Then take it seriously — severe Yang Deficiency, or extreme pain and collapse states.

Maciocia

Moving

動 Dòng

FEEL

Rapid and slippery; forceful specifically at the middle portion.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

A bean bouncing in the vessel — well-defined peaks, no head or tail.

INDICATES

Shock, anxiety, fright. Pain.

Not to be confused with

vs **Slippery**: Moving is forceful only at the middle, like a bean.

COMBINATIONS

Moving-Rapid — Heat

Moving-Slippery — Deficiency of Qi and Phlegm

Moving-Empty — severe depletion of Blood

Moving-Weak — Shock

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

A single bean flicking under one fingertip. Short, rounded, forceful — no lead-in and no tail. It startles you slightly.

Then what

Ask about recent shock, fright, or acute pain. This is often a state rather than a constitution.

Bīn Hú Mài Xué

Hasty

促 Cù

FEEL

Beats rapidly with irregular, random stops.

CLASSICAL IMAGE

Agitated and urgent, like a man running and suddenly falling down.

INDICATES

Severe Heat. Deficiency of Heart-Qi. Heart-Fire.

Not to be confused with

vs **Knotted**: Hasty is rapid; Knotted is slow.

COMBINATIONS

Hasty-Overflowing — Heat in the Stomach

Hasty-Slippery — retention of Phlegm-Heat

Hasty-Wiry — Liver-Fire and Heart-Fire

Hasty-Slippery-Wiry — Heart-Fire, Liver-Fire, and Phlegm-Heat

Hasty-Fine without strength — collapse of Heart-Qi

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Fast and stumbling. Like someone running who trips, recovers, runs, trips again — irregular, at speed.

Then what

Note the speed AND the pause pattern before you name it. Rapid with random stops = Hasty. Slow with random stops = Knotted.

Maciocia

Knotted

結 Jié

FEEL

Slow with irregularly missed beats; the pulse resumes immediately after the missed beat.

INDICATES

Cold with Heart-Yang Deficiency.

Not to be confused with

vs **Hasty**: Knotted is SLOW + random stops; Hasty is RAPID + random stops.

COMBINATIONS

Knotted-Choppy — Blood Stasis

Knotted-Slippery — retention of Phlegm

Knotted-Deep — accumulation in the Interior

Knotted-Wiry — disease of the arteries, or hypertension

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Slow with a hiccup. Beat, beat, gap, beat — and it picks straight back up as though nothing happened.

Then what

Same rule: check speed first. Knotted is the slow one. If it also feels taut, that combination is worth a referral conversation.

Maciocia

Intermittent

代 Dài

FEEL

Pauses at REGULAR intervals; resumes after the pause.

INDICATES

Serious problem in the internal organs. Heart problem (Western medical sense).

Not to be confused with

vs **Knotted/Hasty**: pauses at REGULAR intervals. Most serious of the three.

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

The unsettling one, because there's a pattern. Skip on the fourth beat. Then again on the fourth. Regularity inside the irregularity.

Then what

Count several cycles to confirm the pattern is real. If the pauses are genuinely regular, this needs a cardiac referral — not a treatment principle.

Maciocia

Hurried / Racing

疾 Jí

FEEL

Rapid, beating more than seven times per breath (140–180bpm) — an extreme version of Rapid; rhythm stays regular.

INDICATES

Fire exhausting Yin.

Not to be confused with

vs **Hasty**: Racing is over 7/breath but REGULAR.

COMBINATIONS

Hurried-Floating — severe Empty-Heat from Yin Deficiency

Hurried-Floating-Empty — severe Yin Deficiency

Hurried-Slippery — Empty-Heat from Yin Deficiency with Phlegm

Hurried-Overflowing — Empty-Heat arising from Yin Deficiency

WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Extremely fast but perfectly even — no stumbles. A metronome set far too high.

Then what

Confirm it's regular, which separates it from Hasty. Then check for fever, dehydration, thyroid issues, and escalate if it's sustained.

Maciocia

Red flags — refer

Finding	Means
Intermittent 代	Regular pauses — organ / cardiac. Refer.
Scattered 散	Loses shape, rate uncountable. Serious.
Hasty + Fine, no strength	Collapse of Heart-Qi. Escalate.
Hurried/Racing 疾	Over 7/breath. Fire exhausting Yin.
Hollow + Rapid	Forthcoming hemorrhage.
Flooding in winter	Excess Yang against the season.
Knotted + Wiry	Arterial disease or hypertension.

A pulse you cannot count, cannot find, or that stops on a schedule is a referral conversation — not a treatment-principle conversation.

PART FOUR

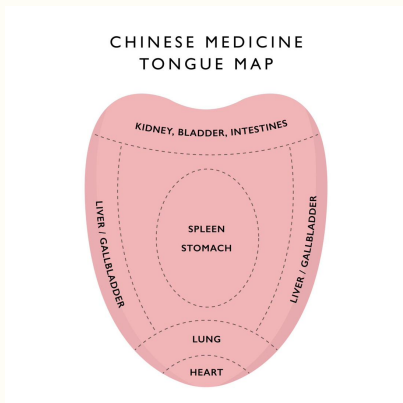
Tongue Diagnosis

舌診 Shé Zhěn

Body color, shape, coating, and the sublingual veins — 21 entries, continuing from the pulse-taking technique in Part Three. The tongue holds a long-term record; the pulse shows the moment.

REFERENCE • TONGUE DIAGNOSIS

Tongue Topography — The Standard Map



Front-to-back mirrors upper-to-lower burner; sides read Liver/Gallbladder at every level. Schrier's rule: get in the right general zone before chasing precision — other diagnostic legs (pulse, symptoms, history) narrow it from there. Other schools map this differently — this is the version used in this course.

How to Inspect the Tongue

望舌 Wàng Shé

Sequence: tip → middle → root, then body → coating. Extend no longer than 15–20 seconds (Schrier: really more like 10 — longer and the tongue starts to quiver on its own).

CONDITIONS TO CONTROL FOR

Natural light, proper posture, diet/medication history, season & time of day, age & constitution (children run more Yang/red; elderly run more dry), gender (post-menses = pale; pre-menses = red, especially sides/Liver).

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Don't take a quick cell-phone-selfie glance and move on — break it into tip/middle/root/body/coating on purpose, every time, or you'll miss the zone that actually matters.

Medications & the Tongue

藥物與舌象

Medication	Effect
Antibiotics	Peeling; resolves in days, coat returns ~2 weeks after stopping
Corticosteroids	Red, swollen tongue; tip more red
Bronchodilators	Red tip (only after years of use)
Diuretics	Peeling
Anti-inflammatories	Red points on tongue; thinner body
Antineoplastics (chemo)	Thick, brown/black, dry coating
Pepto-Bismol	Black coating

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Antibiotics-causes-peeling is Schrier's own flagged favorite test question. If you see peeling with no other yin-deficiency signs, ask about antibiotics before you commit to a diagnosis.

Tongue–Zang Fu Connections

舌與臟腑

Heart: tongue is its sprout — opens to the tongue, enables speech and taste. Stuttering/inability to articulate can trace to the Heart ("the emperor can't make his decree").

Spleen: tongue is its external sign — root of Qi/Blood/Fluids that nourish it; controls the muscles, so Spleen Qi deficiency can show as a faint quiver.

Liver: controls the tendons & the tongue's movement — deviation or involuntary movement points here (Internal Wind).

Lung: passes through the throat; filiform papillae depend on fluids the Lung distributes.

Kidney: a different kind of connection than the four above — not a direct opening, but shares responsibility for coating formation alongside the Stomach, and a black tongue specifically points to Kidney exhaustion.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Each organ leaves a specific fingerprint on the tongue: Heart = speech, Spleen = quiver, Liver = movement, Lung = surface moisture, Kidney = coating and the color black specifically.

Three Layers of the Tongue

舌之三層

Layer	Reflects
Coat	Wei (Defensive) Qi — the most superficial layer
Body	Ying (Nutritive) Qi — Blood and fluids
Sublingual veins	Yuan (Source/Constitutional) Qi — the deepest layer

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Coat is your coat (protects against Wind/Cold/Damp). Body is the meaty, Blood-carrying part. Sublingual veins are the deepest read — the constitutional layer underneath everything else.

The Normal Tongue

正常舌

Pale-red body (not bright red), fits the mouth — not swollen, thin, cracked, stiff, or loose. No ulcers. Thin white coat. Slightly moist (neither too dry nor too wet). Sublingual veins not distended. Has *Shén* — a sense of vitality, not a shriveled/lifeless look.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Goldilocks: not too red, not too pale, not too wet, not too dry.

Almost nobody is perfectly normal — everyone carries at least a little something, because everyone lives a life.

Pale Tongue

淡白舌

Blood Deficiency: pale, thin, dry-ish. Not enough Blood to nourish/redden the tongue.

Yang Deficiency: pale AND wet/swollen. Not enough Yang to mobilize fluids, so they pool. Accompanied by cold limbs, poor appetite, loose stools, Deep-Slow pulse.

By position: pale on the sides → Liver Blood deficiency (dry eyes, scanty periods, poor sleep). Pale in the center → Spleen/Stomach Blood deficiency.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Same pale color, two different mechanisms: dry-pale = not enough Blood being made. Wet-pale = enough Blood, but nothing pushing/warming it to the surface.

Red Tongue

紅舌

Feature	Full (Excess)	Empty (Deficient)
Coating	Present (coat = a layer = Full)	Absent/peeled
Tip	Heart Fire	Heart Empty Heat
Sides	Liver Fire/Liver-Yang Rising	Liver Yin deficiency
Center	Stomach/Spleen Fire	Stomach Yin deficiency

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Red = Heat, always. Coating on it = you're looking at Full Heat (you put a coat/layer on). No coating = Empty Heat (the layers came off).

Red Points & Spots

紅點

Raised points indicate Fire specifically (more Yang, more concentrated than plain Heat). Location still maps normally: tip=Heart Fire, sides=Liver Fire, root=Lower Burner Fire. Fire signs beyond the tongue: outbursts of anger, more drying, bleeding (heat pushes Blood out of the vessels), manic/agitated mental state.

Points on the outer edge in an external disease → Wind-Heat at the exterior, not yet penetrated in.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Don't auto-answer "Fire" just because you see points — the specific organ still has to match the rest of the question. Points bias toward Fire over plain Heat, that's all.

Purple & Blue Tongue

紫舌 · 青舌

Purple (any shade) = Blood Stasis, full stop. **Reddish-purple** = Stasis arising from Heat. **Bluish-purple/blue** = Stasis arising from Cold (or plain Interior Cold if no purple yet). Excess Heat causing stasis: purple + dry + cracks. Excess Cold causing stasis: purple + wet.

By position: sides = Liver Blood Stasis (in women, often uterus-linked via the Liver); center = Spleen/Stomach Blood Stasis.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Purple, you say Blood Stasis. Reddish-purple, the stasis came from heat cooking the blood thick. Bluish-purple, it came from cold freezing the blood still.

Black & Gray Tongue

黑舌 · 灰舌

Quality	Meaning
Glossy/greasy (either color)	Damp-Cold, Yang deficiency
Dry/cracked (either color)	Extreme Heat, or Kidney exhaustion (black specifically)

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Black is the true classical color for Water/Kidney (not blue — that's a modern translation drift). Same logic as gray, just one step further down the depletion scale: shiny/wet = cold water pooling, dry/cracked = the well has run dry.

Thin Tongue

瘦舌

Blood or Yin deficiency — not enough substance to fill the body out. Pale-thin = Blood deficiency (accompanied by pale lips, palpitations, thready pulse). Red-thin without coating = Yin deficiency.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Thin tongue = not enough material. Color tells you which material is missing: pale means Blood, red-and-peeled means Yin/fluids.

Swollen Tongue

胖舌

Swollen = Dampness/Phlegm **or** Heat — color is the tiebreaker.
Pale + swollen = Spleen Qi/Yang deficiency generating Damp.
Red + swollen = Damp-Heat or Phlegm-Heat.

By position: swollen at chest/breast zone (front third, sides) = Phlegm in the chest/Lung. Swollen in center + pale = Spleen Qi deficiency generating Damp (no heat signs needed to call this one).

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Swollen alone is ambiguous on purpose — it's the exam's favorite trap. Always check color and look for real heat signs (thirst, redness, irritability) before deciding Damp vs. Damp-Heat.

Scalloped / Tooth-Marked Tongue

齒痕舌

Spleen Qi deficiency. Mechanism: Spleen Qi can't transform/transport → tongue bloats slightly → pushes against the teeth → scalloped edges. Long-standing Spleen Qi deficiency generates Dampness in the body (Earth's climatic pathogen).

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Don't jump to Liver/Gallbladder just because the marks sit on the sides — scalloping is a Spleen-Qi sign specifically, regardless of which edge it shows up on.

Cracks

裂紋舌

Horizontal cracks: Yin deficiency of Stomach and/or Kidney.

Stomach crack (central, wide): Stomach Yin deficiency; width/depth tracks severity; darkish-yellow inside the crack = accompanying Heat.

Heart crack: runs to (or near) the tip. Signs: palpitations, easily startled, poor sleep (Heart Blood deficiency — no Blood to anchor the Shen).

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

A crack is a dry riverbed — fluids that should be there have receded. Location tells you which organ's fluids ran out first.

Quivering, Moving & Deviated Tongue

顫動舌 · 歪斜舌

Quivering (gentle shake): Spleen Qi deficiency — muscles (Spleen-governed) too weak to hold steady.

Moving (stronger, restless movement): Liver Wind.

Deviated (pushed to one side): Internal Wind — but rule out a structural cause (old jaw/dental injury, TMJ) before committing to that diagnosis.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Quiver = a tremor, gentle. Moving = active, restless. Deviated = off to one side. All three trace back to Liver/Wind territory except when the deviation is just an old injury talking.

Coating Color

苔色

Color	Meaning
White	Cold (can be normal if thin)
Yellow	Heat
Gray	Extreme Heat or Extreme Cold — check moisture to tell apart
Black	Extreme Heat or Extreme Cold (same ambiguity as gray)

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Gray and black don't resolve on color alone — wet/glossy points cold, dry/cracked points heat. Color gets you to the pathogen family; moisture gets you to hot-or-cold.

Coating Thickness & Distribution

苔厚薄 · 苔之分布

Thin = weaker/earlier-stage pathogen (or normal). Thick = stronger, more interior pathogen. Front-to-back roughly mirrors Exterior→Interior progression: front half coating = pathogen entering but not deep; rear half = already affecting Stomach/deeper structures.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Thin coating = a light dusting, early innings. Thick coating = built-up grime, the pathogen's been at it a while. More coat, more work to clear it.

Coating Moisture

苔潤燥

Glossy (wet, transparent, near-dripping): Yang Qi fails to transform fluids → Damp/Cold accumulation. Fluids are present, just not being processed.

Rough (dry, sandpaper-like): severe injury to Body Fluids — they're actually gone, not just unprocessed.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Glossy means the fluids are there but stuck (a plumbing problem). Rough means the fluids themselves are damaged (a supply problem). Different treatment principle entirely.

Coating Viscosity

苔膩

Moldy: thick, patchy, coarse granules — easily wiped/scraped off. Food stagnation, Phlegm, internal abscess.

Greasy: sticky, fine particles, thicker center/thinner margins — difficult to wipe off. Damp-Phlegm, food stagnation; an excess pathogen obstructing Yang, followed by Damp stagnation.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Moldy = cottage cheese on your shirt — one wipe and it's gone.
Greasy = peanut butter on your shirt — you just smear it around.
Same Damp/Phlegm family; the wipe test is the tell.

Peeling & Rootless Coating

剥苔 · 無根苔

Peeled/no coating = Yin deficiency, most often Stomach Yin specifically (Stomach is the postnatal source of fluids). A coating with no root (sits on top, not grown from the body, easily brushed away) shows Stomach Qi/Yin already damaged — even a thick rootless coat is worse than it looks. A coating WITH root, even if thick and nasty, means Stomach Qi is still holding — a better sign.

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Coating should grow out of the tongue the way grass grows out of soil, roots and all. Rootless coating is grass clippings someone scattered on top — looks similar, means the opposite.

Sublingual Veins

舌下絡脈

Finding	Meaning
Distended, not dark	Qi deficiency
Thin	Yin deficiency
Distended and dark	Blood Stasis, Upper Burner
Dark and dry	Severe Yin deficiency with Empty Heat
Dark, swollen, wet	Lung/Spleen/Kidney deficiency
Reddish and shiny	Damp-Heat
White and slippery	Cold-Damp

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

The deepest layer (Yuan Qi) — if a patient can't lift their tongue to show you, the top view alone is still enough to work with.

Looking Ahead

VOLUME 1

Everything in this book turns into muscle memory eventually. Give it time. Underneath the memorizing is the version of you that's going to be a licensed practitioner — closer than it feels right now.

A reminder for the hard weeks

Motivation = Expectancy $\times$ Value, minus Cost. When studying feels impossible, it's usually the Cost term spiking, not proof you don't believe in yourself or don't care about the work. Lower the cost where you can — sleep, a smaller task, one page instead of ten — before assuming the other two are the problem.

What's Next — Volume 2

Observation & Inspection, Inquiry, the rest of Palpation, and Listening & Smelling — the remaining Four Pillars, same format: one finding per page, top from the lecture, bottom in plain language.

To be continued.